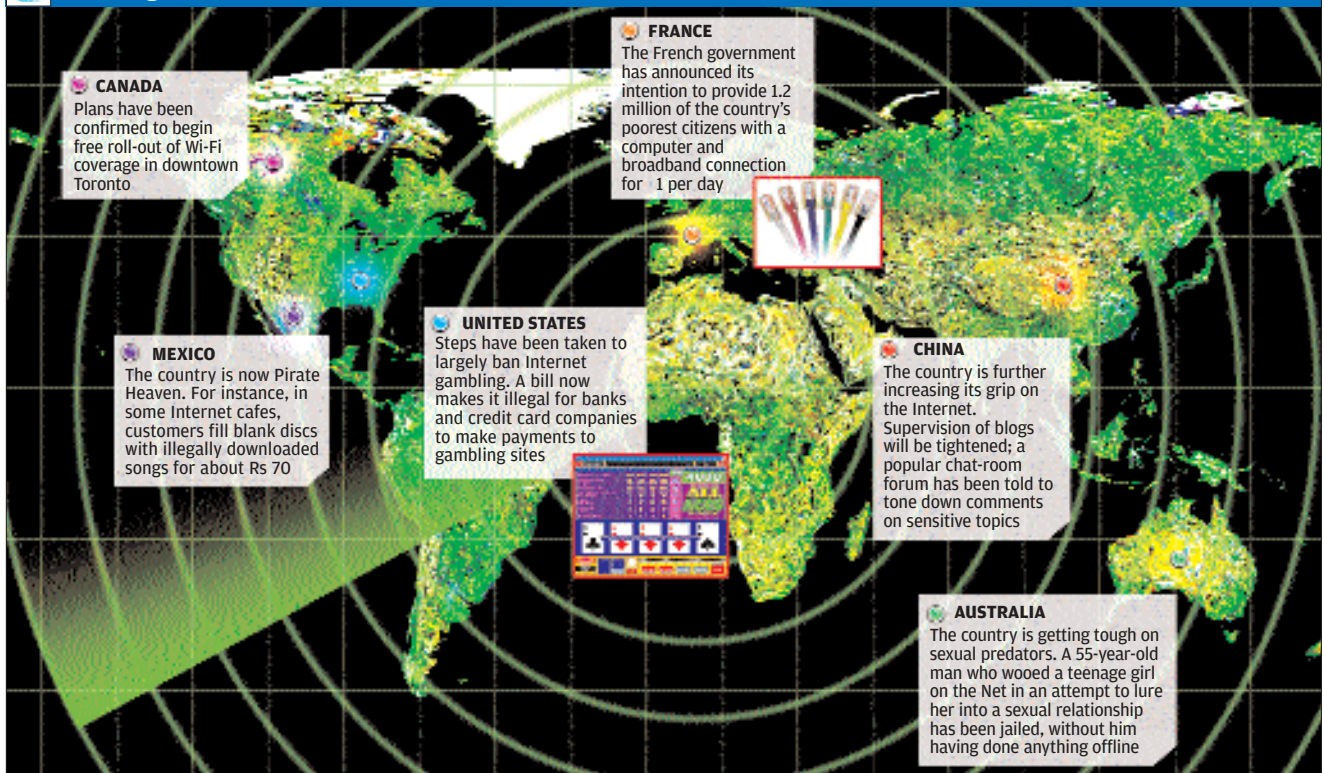




WHO'S TO BLAME?

It's Getting Tougher On The Kids

Last month's cover story was about what kids are exposed to in the adult world online. But when talking of children and the Internet, one also needs to consider what they are exposing online—on social networking sites, for example, or video-sharing sites.

Statistics are available for some countries, which could be representative of the situation in others. In Britain, an alarming 61 per cent of children aged 13 to 17 have a personal profile on some social networking site. Alarming because some of them are giving out personal details. Some are showing off intimate photographs of themselves as part of their profile. Many are going on to physically meet people they've encountered online. Now consider that in

conjunction with the fact that more than 50,000 sexual predators are estimated to be online at any given time.

Teachers and parents alike are now alarmed at how children are using the sites, including Bebo, Facebook, Friendster, and MySpace.

In Australia, a study has found that 40 per cent of teens "would" physically meet someone they'd met online, and that only 12 per cent would ask their parents permission to do so.

Bebo organises networks around schools, so predators have all they need—the schools' addresses along with the names, pictures, and ages of the kids on the site. And the kids are to blame, too, if kids can indeed be blamed: girls as young as 13 show pictures of themselves in sexual poses—semi-nude or in lingerie.

The phenomenon has not gone unnoticed: the sites are coming under scrutiny. A certain head teacher of a school in England actually called in police after she found that



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